Twelve Small Things to Notice About How Dad Likes His Day, and Ask Him About

Everyday details to jot down, each with a question for him, and nothing to read into any of them.

You've watched Dad make breakfast a thousand times. You may never have noticed the order he does it in. This guide names twelve everyday details worth noticing and, for each, what to jot down and what to ask him.

This isn't a watch for anything. Dad is well, and nothing on this list is a sign of something else. Noticing only gives you something real to ask about; whether a habit matters to him is his to say. There's nothing secret about it either. Tell him what you're doing, and show him the page.

The areas follow the everyday headings of The Conversation Project's workbook and of two Alzheimer's Association resources, its Personal Facts and Insights sheet and its page on communication. Those two were written with dementia care in mind. We've used only their everyday questions about routines, food, company, names and conversation, and nothing here assumes that applies to Dad. The twelve items and the wording about what to write down are ours.

His mornings and evenings

1 How he starts the day [1]

NOTICE The order of his morning: the kettle, the paper, the radio, the walk to the mailbox, and which comes first.

WRITE DOWN The order as you see it, and a question for him: which part would he least want hurried?

2 How he ends the day [1]

NOTICE The last hour: a program, a book, a phone call, a turn around the house to lock up, and roughly when the light goes off.

WRITE DOWN What you see, and a question for him: is that how he likes it, or just how it has worked out?

At the table

3 When he eats

NOTICE When the meals actually happen, and which one is the main one. It may not be the timetable you grew up with.

WRITE DOWN The usual times, and a question for him: are those the times he'd choose?

4 What he chooses and what he leaves [1]

NOTICE What he orders, what he makes for himself, what he takes seconds of, what stays on the plate.

WRITE DOWN What you saw. It goes down as a like or a dislike only once he's said so, so ask.

5 What gets said about food and his health [1] [4]

NOTICE Remarks like “Dad can't have that,” a diet sheet on the fridge, the things he turns down and gives a reason for.

WRITE DOWN Who said it and where it's written, on a list of its own, apart from his likes. Ask him whether it's a taste or something a doctor told him. If nobody is sure, the question goes to his doctor or pharmacist.

His pastimes and his people

6 How he fills an afternoon [1] [2]

NOTICE The garden, the workshop, the crossword, the ball game on the radio, and what he gets on with unprompted.

WRITE DOWN What and when, and a question for him: what does he like about it?

7 What goes into a pastime

NOTICE Everything an outing involves from start to finish: the ride to the Thursday card game, the friend who picks him up, the seat he likes.

WRITE DOWN What it involves, with no judgment attached, and a question for him: what makes it easy to keep going?

8 Who he calls and sees [1]

NOTICE Who phones, who he phones, who drops by, and whether he seems to like a full house or one or two people at a time.

WRITE DOWN Names and how often, with no ranking. Ask him who he most looks forward to seeing.

How he likes to be treated

9 What people call him [1]

NOTICE What friends, neighbors and the people at the barber shop call him, and how he introduces himself.

WRITE DOWN The names you hear, and a question for him: what would he want someone new to call him?

10 How conversations go best [3] [1]

NOTICE Where and how he seems most at ease talking: at the kitchen table, on the phone, by email, first thing or after supper, in a quick exchange or a long sit-down.

WRITE DOWN What you've seen, and a question for him: how does he like to be reached, and how does he like to be asked things?

11 What he does somewhere unfamiliar [1]

NOTICE How he settles into a place he doesn't know, like a hotel or a relative's house: the seat he picks, what he brings along, what he asks about first.

WRITE DOWN What you saw, and a question for him: what helps him feel comfortable somewhere new?

The family's version

12 What the family says about him

NOTICE The things relatives state as fact: “Dad hates a fuss,” “he's always been up at five.” And the moments when what he does doesn't match.

WRITE DOWN The belief and whose it is, marked “not yet asked.” Then ask him, and write his answer beside it.

If something about his health is on your mind

This list isn't for that. It's about how Dad likes his day, and nothing on it calls for a phone call. If you do have a concern about his health, that's a conversation for him and his doctor, not something to work out from these notes. And anything on your list about an allergy or a doctor's instruction is a question for his doctor or pharmacist.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of this means, and it isn't a way of keeping an eye on him. Nothing here measures how he's doing, and nothing you notice becomes a preference until he says it is. It gives you better questions, and his answers are the ones that count.

Ready for the next step?

You've noticed the small things and written each one down as a question for Dad. The care interview is where his answers go: it walks you through his situation area by area, his preferences included, and turns what you enter into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Alzheimer's Association, Personal Facts and Insights (form)
2. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement) and Ariadne Labs, What Matters to Me: A Workbook for Better Health Care
3. Alzheimer's Association, Communication and Alzheimer's
4. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Food Allergy